

Automating Evidence Collection via IBM Concert

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The manual collection of audit evidence is a resource-intensive process prone to human error, data tampering, and high rejection rates. By implementing a "SMART Workflow" via IBM Concert, organizations can transition from a two-week manual collection cycle to an automated, "push-button" process completed in hours. This solution ensures 100% data integrity and a tamper-proof chain of custody through SHA256 hashing, effectively eliminating the friction between Operations (OPS), Security Operations (SECOPS), and external auditors.

PROBLEM DESCRIPTION

The traditional audit evidence collection process is defined by high manual effort and significant technical impediments. The current state for T-OPS involves:

- **Labor Intensity:** Dedicated teams spend two weeks per audit cycle manually capturing screenshots and compiling work documents.
- **Scale and Complexity:** Evidence must be gathered from 40 to 80 Configuration Items (CIs) across both Windows and Linux environments.
- **Workflow Inefficiency:** SECOPS acts as a middleman between OPS and demanding external auditors. If an audit is rejected, the process must be restarted from scratch.
- **Automation Impediments:** Previous reluctance to automate stemmed from critical concerns regarding:
 - Accuracy of Date/Time stamps.
 - Maintaining a secure Chain of Custody.
 - Prevention of Evidence Tampering.
 - General Data Integrity and Quality.

OBJECTIVE AND SOLUTION

The primary objective is to replace "weeks of manual and hectic efforts" with a zero-touch, 100% compliant automated system.

The Solution: IBM Concert SMART Workflow

IBM Concert addresses the core impediments of audit automation through an end-to-end digital pipeline:

- **Data Integrity:** SHA256 hashing is employed to ensure evidence remains tamper-proof and the chain of custody is uncompromised.
- **Efficiency:** The solution delivers consolidated reports in hours rather than weeks, utilizing 24/7 automated resources.

- **Quality:** The "Perfect formatted output" provides a single table containing CI details, control details, and audit evidence, resulting in zero rejections from external auditors.

STRATEGIC INTEGRATION

- **IBM Turbonomics:** Validates compliance status across the complete infrastructure.
- **IBM Watsonx.ai:** Enables the rapid creation of new workflows within IBM Concert.
- **Proactive Compliance:** The system allows "Pre-Audits" to maintain compliance quality before external reviews.

WORKFLOW

The SMART Workflow follows a standardized seven-step process within the IBM Concert ecosystem:

Step	Action
1	Access: Login to IBM Concert.
2	Navigation: Access the Automation Center Panel.
3	Initiation: Start the Audit Evidence collection Workflow.
4	Selection: Select or Import CI Samples (Windows/Linux).
5	Configuration: Select the required Audit Controls.
6	Execution: Submit the request.
7	Delivery: A Hashed ZIP file is automatically emailed to the T-OPS requester and T-SECOPS for validation.

SMART WORKFLOW MIND MAP

- **IBM Concert (Central Hub)**
 - **Inputs:** CI Samples (Win/Linux) + Selected Controls.
 - **Security Layer:** SHA256 Hashing + No Human Intervention.
 - **Outputs:** Consolidated HTML Report + Hashed ZIP File.
 - **Stakeholders:** T-OPS (Requester) & T-SECOPS (Validator).

MIND MAP PICTURE

